

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH *of Los Angeles*

Pentecost 7

Another Kind of Freedom ~ The Heart of Service
19 July 2026



*Heart shaped map of the world from Paris, 1536
by Oronce Finé*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, Guest Organist

Prelude and Fugue in B Major, op. 7, no. 1, Marcel Dupré (1886-1971)

St. Francis of Assisi preaching to the birds, Franz Liszt (1811-1886); arr. Camille

Saint-Saëns (1835-1921)

Prélude, Nadia Boulanger (1887-1979)

Grand Chœur Dialogue, Eugène Gigout (1844-1925)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Lisa Domke & Sharon Duncan

Through little acts of kindness –
the healing powers that lie within a smile,
and the miracles worked by gentle words of praise –
we touch and change the human face of this world.

Only by the power of the human heart
does misery turn to beauty,
despair to new life,
and the killing weight of endless suffering
become the freedom of possibility.

And life calls us – once more –
to celebrate its presence with love,
the deep and burning kind of love
that costs so much.

May we find within our own hearts
the power of that love waiting to be spilled
freely and lavishly
in every place
we might find need.
This world is ours to serve and to heal.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering** *Holy, Wondrous Mystery, Birthing All Creation*

NICAEA

Holy wondrous mystery, birthing all creation,
Every day your songs arise from nature's harmony.
Holy, wondrous mystery, breath of our formation,
Source of all life throughout infinity.

Holy wondrous mystery, one in all things dwelling,
Everywhere in everyone you bring divinity.
Holy, sacred presence, loving and compelling,
Living and moving through eternity.

Holy wondrous mystery, darkness magnifies you,
In the darkened depths of soil you root and sprout and thrive
Holy, spacious darkness, moon and sun shine through you.
Stars on your canvas bring the skies to life.

Holy wondrous mystery, birthing all creation,
All your works resound in praise from earth and sky and sea.
Holy wondrous mystery, glorious revelation,
Song of all life throughout infinity.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Lisa Domke

O God, in this, our gathering time,
may our hearts be open to the stirring
of holiness.

May it cause us to know grace and love
in those places where
seeds of judgment were sown.

May it allow us to soothe our pain-filled
memories with peace.

May it help us to experience joy
in the divine presence
of all our gathered siblings
from near and far.

*On this day, as we open our hearts to the stirring of holiness,
may we know your grace and love
in this sacred space and time -
and then - may all people across the world,
inhabit these gifts in the days to come.
Amen and Amen.*

***Introit**

"Love Is Little"
Cathedral Choir, Miriam Adhonom, *Conductor*

arr. DAVID GARCÍA SALDAÑA

***The Lord's Prayer**

Sharon Duncan

*Creator of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.
May your dreams of justice, love, compassion, and
connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourished
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys and
liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power-over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and our strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[enfleshed/adpt/lvf]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Lisa Domke

There is no greater service that we offer
than to heal the sick,
to clothe the naked,
to find water for those that thirst,
to bind up the broken-hearted –
much is asked of us
only because we know, in our depths,
that we are capable.

As we fill ourselves
with the gifts of peace in this hour,
may we also fill our hearts to overflowing
with an urgent need
to do the work to which we are called.

Together, may we overflow in our zeal
for a realm of justice and peace,
of equity for all.

May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

from Philippians

Sharon Duncan

Do nothing out of selfish ambition or vain conceit. Rather, in humility value others above yourselves, not looking to your own interests but each of you to the interests of the others.

For this witness of the ancients...

Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Lisa Domke

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Creator and Creative God, on this day, we long to live in harmony with all creation, to daily find ways to heal our world, her peoples and all that share life upon her.

For we know that doing so is to participate in your ever-flowing river of healing, is to co-create the universe as you intend it, full of wholeness, justice, and peace for all.

Because of your love, may all that confines and hinders that flourishing within and among us fall away.

Because of your love, empower us to lose ourselves into this life with devotion and desire, that we may find our true selves in service, compassion, and mercy.

Because of your love, may we know the ways that make for peace, in our souls and in this world.

*And then, O God, help love to so inhabit our world,
that we will give our lives to its path both this day,
and forever more.*

Amen and Amen.

[jrichardson/adptlvf]

Meditation Anthem

"You All Have My Love"

TANNER PFEIFFER

Tanner Pfeiffer, Soloist, Dr. Jaebon Hwang, Piano

Sermon

The Heart of Service

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Lisa Domke

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"God, Make Me An Instrument"
Cathedral Choir

ROGER HOLLAND II

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Sharon Duncan

Holy One,
Today, we remember all who have
brought your gifts to us.

We give thanks for those who cloak
themselves in humility,
and, who, through their service,
show us a more excellent way.

In these coming days, O God,
may we learn from them
and may we too, offer our gifts
to those who need us the most.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

May the Mystery we call God
keep alive in each of us
the search for Love that is real;
Love that helps us live more joyful lives;
Love that gives us a fuller
meaning to life and the events of life;
Love that serves and shares and
insists on what might yet be.

*Bring us, O God, the goodness that flows
from your heart of Love,
and may we be expanded in heart and soul
by that Love.*
This is our prayer.

Choral Response

"Walk Together, Children" Laude

MOSES HOGAN

*Hymn for the Journey

In the Midst of All Our Living

NETTLETON

In the midst of every blessing, may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness, ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May our words be filled with gratitude; may our glad hearts humble be.
As a holder of a blessing, may we share it gratefully.

In the midst of every trial, may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of comfort, ever flowing, call for songs of highest praise.
May we find the strength within us; may we sense it everywhere.
As we face what must be handled, may we find truth we can share.

In the midst of all our living, may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May we seek and find encouragement; may our choices worthy be.
As we journey on together, may we know integrity.

-Lyrics by Scott Kearns, 2008, inspired by Robert Robinson, 1758

Postlude

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

Nicaea, arr. Craig Phillips (b. 1961)

Inside The Music

"We have all come to love Roger Holland's setting of St. Francis' famous poem. Holland is one of those composers who seamlessly integrates multiple musical styles into something new in itself. This piece is distinctly marked by his gospel upbringing, and reaches wider to create a more universal statement of faith. The tenderness of his unison lines unfold into sharp points of harmonic distinction along each of St. Francis' juxtaposed articulations. The real magic of the music comes at the end, though, as the choir is invited to release into their voices and out of their bodies as they sing long, loud, luscious chords until the final moment when the word "peace" releases as if into the atmosphere, our souls at rest. Tanner will sing their "You All Have My Love" today. The lyrics come from a family member for whose funeral the piece was written. Tanner explained to me that: "The opening lyrics are the last words I heard her say at a benefit to raise funds for her cancer treatment; the rest of the text is an expansion of her thought that I thought the family would want to hear." The music swims through key centers in a musical smoothness that I've come to appreciate about Tanner's music. Each new turn is a new moment of expression. Tanner added these words about the piece: "After my cousin Trish was diagnosed with cancer, her Midwestern small town community got together to do a spaghetti feed fundraiser for her medical costs. Near the end of the event, Trish got on the microphone and told us all, "Don't you think for one moment that I don't love every last one of you. There is something in all of you that is lovable and beautiful." At her mother Doris' funeral 10 years before, Trish had asked me in the moment to read the eulogy she had written for Doris, but I shook my head because I was crying too hard. The next best thing I could do was to be Trish's voice at her own funeral after the cancer took its toll. I took her words from the fundraiser and expanded them into this song, hoping to share with her friends and family what Trish would want them to know." I also love about this piece the idea that in sharing love with each other we are charging ourselves up for future service to others who will need that same love." ~ Dr. David Harris